

the polls show that Argentines are the world's most optimistic people.

Argentina has had a declining standard of living for decades. Grandparents live better than parents. Parents live better than children. Yet Argentines insist that next year will be better. After a bad year, when Gallup returns and points out that last year's optimism was unfounded, Argentines admit they made a mistake. Then they quickly insist that good times are just around the corner. And so on, year after year.

When people are that optimistic it's infectious. Nothing ever goes too wrong; something better is always on the way. The optimism translates into a wonderful, childlike enthusiasm for birthdays, outdoor barbecues with friends, or simply a sunny day. Argentines ignore life's little hardships and focus instead on a soccer game, a new dress, or a funny drawing. One learns to relax and enjoy each day instead of struggling to prepare for tomorrow.

Move to Argentina and you not only have to learn a new language, you have to adapt to some different customs. Perhaps because it's farther away, Argentina seems less influenced by the United States than other South American countries. Better restaurants in Buenos Aires open at ten in the evening, parties can start at midnight, and jazz clubs open their doors at one in the morning. Arrive on time to a dinner party and there's a good chance the hostess will be out doing last-minute shopping. If she happens to be home, she may greet you in a bathrobe. Formal dinners can include as many as three or four desserts, one after the other, until four or five in the morning.

Argentines love to talk, but according to certain rules. All conversations start with inquiries about one's health and family. All conversations end with best wishes for one's health and family. In between, subject matter varies. But whatever is discussed, images, concepts, and metaphor are preferred to facts, figures, or anything that can be objectively proved or disproved.